

The Onomastics of Pasinetti

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Toward the middle of Pasinetti's novel *Rosso veneziano*, we find the clearest hint to the reader that the author has named his characters with special care. Giorgio has had an intriguing encounter with an attractive young woman whose name he has not learned; relating the experience to his friend Enrico, he says, however, that she "si chiama Blumenfeld," thus bringing the girl into the orbit of a whole Blumenfeld family long an object of charm and fascination for Giorgio. "Blumenfeld," he declares, "è un nome bellissimo; ed è un nome al quale . . . mi sento molto intimamente legato . . . Quel nome, Blumenfeld, l'ho offerto così, nell'immaginazione, a una ragazza ignota che m'è piaciuta, come avrei potuto offrire un fiore; il nome vuol appunto dire 'campo di fiori,' no?" (p. 295-96).¹ This explication confirms what the reader has sensed from the beginning of the novel: the evocative power, the subtle resonances of Pasinetti's onomastics.

Take Partibon and Fassola, designating, as the author's preface points out, the two Venetian families, one of *artisti* and the other of *politici*, around whom the action of the novel is polarized. Both surnames are characteristically Venetian: the first, with its oxytonic accentuation; the second, with a root found frequently in Venice (an old telephone book for the city reveals Fassa, Fassetta, Fassi, Fassina, Fassini, Fasson—but no Fassola, for Pasinetti seems to have been extremely careful not to use real names). But there is more.

Partibon gives us immediately *bon parti*, the "good" side which, indeed, engages our sympathies from the start. If we "joyce" further the name of this family of artists and individualists, we arrive at Bonaparte, which, for all the mixed resonances the name of Napoleon sets up elsewhere, is in Italy (as in Stendahl) a symbol of liberalism. The interpretation of Fassola involves a different etymology: given that the standard Tuscan—sc—corresponds to—ss—in Venetian, the name clearly suggests Fascism (*fascio* plus the insignificant ending *la*). And, indeed, one member of the family is an important official of the Fascist government, while another is a hero of the Fascist Air Force. It is irrelevant that no one in the Fassola family is portrayed as a bestial character. The family as a whole, according to the author's avowed intent, is representative of the dominant Italian political experience of the 1930's: the sanguine acceptance of a Fascism turned toward health, youth, the future, and an orderly body politic.

This initial grouping of the principal characters by families is carried still further by their given names. The centers of the action are Giorgio and Elena, the children of a celebrated painter, Paolo Partibon. These, the representatives of the essential Partibon spirit, have simple, Italian names. More Latinate (but not grandiose) are Vittoria and Giuliano, the names of Paolo's wife and eldest son; these characters exist outside the charmed circle of the other three and constitute the practical, down-to-earth side of the family. The grandmother, whose death opens the book, has a fairly uncommon name, Elisabetta, and is truly the queen of the family. The grouping by names is found also in the arrangement of the names of Elisabetta's children. Her sons are Paolo and the missing Marco, the focus of much of Giorgio and Elena's attention; the matriarch's daughters are Delia and Ersilia (and the long-

deceased Clotilde), who, with their fanciful, more "romantic" names are distinctly set apart; there is something almost absurd about being named for Apollo's isle and Romulus' wife (Hersilia). On the third page of the narrative, we learn from Elena's interior monologue that she, her father (Paolo), even her mother (Vittoria), and especially Giorgio have continued the normal tenor of their life, in spite of the grandmother's imminent death: "niente in comune con le zie piangenti."

Just as simple first names are borne by those of the essential Partibon spirit, there is a pattern to the Fassola names, which suggests the neo-Roman bombast of the Fascists: Hermes, Augustus, Fausta, and Maximus were gods or rulers. The two middle-aged brothers (of the same generation as Paolo Partibon) are Ermete, the Minister of Public Works, and Augusto, the lawyer. The latter's wife, who plays an almost incidental role, is nonetheless called Fausta. The younger son, very Fassola, is called Massimo, and we shall return to him later. The other son, Enrico, serves well to bring these names into focus, for he aspires, not only to Elena's hand, but to the Partibon spirit. He is a Fassola *manqué*, with none of the virtues admired by his uncle or his father, who, moreover, darkly intuits the fascination which the Partibon family holds for Enrico.

Ruggero Tava, assimilated to the Partibon circle despite the years of his estrangement from Giorgio and Elena, provides a noteworthy example of the subtlety with which Pasinetti chooses names to reflect his personages. While the Fassolas represent the *politici* and the Partibons the *artisti*, Ruggero Tava is the novel's sole representative of a dying race: the aristocratic soldier. He is, in fact, the last son of the "punto debole d'una famiglia di militari," (p. 107) the Mar-

chese Emanuele Tava d'Usmè. In Ruggero's case, it is principally the first name which has affective value, with its overtones of Ariostan chivalry. Giorgio and Elena always refer to him as Ruggero, whereas certain other characters, like Enzo Bolchi, are always called by their surnames. Ruggero's family name is nevertheless resonant of chivalry. From the start, one "knows" that Tava is somehow essentially aristocratic and wholly *right* for this figure. Surely Tava is a delicate echo of *tavola rotonda*.

The first thing we learn about Ruggero Tava is that he was involved, years before, in a duel with Bolchi: in a crescendo of allusions, we then learn that Elena loved him, and she feels he is irrevocably lost to her because of the duel. We finally hear the whole story: at the age of 16, Ruggero slapped Bolchi who had insulted Elena. Giorgio tells us that Bolchi's desire for physical revenge takes the form of a duel and is the direct result of a sentence dropped by Giorgio and Elena "al momento psicologico esatto, *Fra Ruggero e Bolchi, è evidente, non rimane altra soluzione che la vertenza cavalleresca*" (p. 119). In their evocation of this duel, Giorgio and Elena recall Ruggero's aristocratic elegance and calm, his "coraggio individuale, tranquillo, elegante, pulito" (p. 120). Even Bolchi will remember Ruggero as "un combattente sicuro e cavalleresco, un avversario pieno di generosità e di coraggio" (p. 521). In the second episode involving Ruggero, where he and Elena meet again and become lovers, we learn, this time from his point of view, that he had fought "con una sicurezza ed una precisione che non s'era mai conosciuto, come se ogni gesto gli fosse dettato da una forza fin allora ignota, e una volta scoperta, inesauribile" (p. 184). This brings Ruggero even further into the realm of chivalric romance, where knights fighting for their lady's honor are endowed

with almost supernatural powers. What is more, this same interior monologue reveals that for the young Ruggero, the duel was not only to defend Elena but to win her: ". . . e che Elena sarebbe stata finalmente sua, capita da lui, protetta da lui." He had intended not to kill Bolchi, but to make "un solo, lungo sfregio su quel volto," deep enough to be permanent and bloody enough to end the combat. This paragraph closes with the phrase "e poi ne sarebbe andato con Elena," which, with Ruggero's boyish plans for carrying her off to an aunt's castle near the border, confirms his role as a chivalric hero.

Ruggero does not reappear for almost 250 pages; when he does, it is to tell Matelda Kraus that his wife is pregnant; the chapter ends with Matelda explaining to Ruggero and Elena that, in the most impossible situation, they seem to be the "eternal couple," the perfect husband and wife. This is followed by a brief scene in Ruggero's apartment; when Elena leaves, the episode closes with the following:

C'era sempre stato, nelle loro vite, l'amore reciproco come un punto fisso: essersi conosciuti, come negli ultimi tempi, aveva significato dare un nome alle cose, svelarle, leggere la propria stessa esistenza. Ora, perciò, vedendo Elena scendere e allontanarsi da lui, Ruggero poteva continuare a sentirsi calmo e lieto, perché tutto fra loro si era svolto nella verità; anche quand'era lontana Elena rimaneva una parte di lui, gli aveva permesso di dare un senso alla propria vita, oltre ogni possibile speranza.

(p. 461)

Theirs is, of course, a hopeless situation: Ruggero's wife knows of his affair with Elena, his father proffers vague sentences about "assoluta correttezza reciproca," and his uncle, the famous general, says, inappropriately, "Che tu voglia fare il tuo dovere, Ruggero, è ovvio, è scontato, sei un Tava. I sentimenti poi, non si discu-

tono" (p. 461). At the end of the novel, his father will also say that Ruggero would have done his duty, and Giorgio asks, "What duty?"

Ruggero is killed at the front, a sort of hero in spite of himself, leaving both his wife and Elena pregnant: it is the death of Tristan, no longer obliged to choose between the two Isolde. What is potentially a tragic event becomes a sad one, since it offers the only possible issue. Northrop Frye has written that the death of the hero of romance "has the affect of a spirit passing out of nature, and evokes a mood best described as elegiac" (*The Anatomy of Criticism*, p. 36). There is something of this elegiac mood in Ruggero's case: we learn no details of his death, except that it has taken place in the Alps.

The death of Ruggero is paralleled by that of Massimo Fassola, the very incarnation of the Fascist ideal. Robust, athletic, voracious in his appetites, he is the youngest captain in the Italian Air Force. He, too, dies for his country, but in his case we know the horrible details, which are repeated several times: he crashes in a test flight and is burned. This absurd death, spoken of as "la fine eroica del povero Massimo" (p. 414), is recompensed by a medal and a "bella cerimonia," whereas Ruggero, who actually died in a battle he hardly believed in, receives no such honors. Massimo and Ruggero, who do not know each other, are linked by other things besides their youthful sacrifices for their country. Massimo, too, had fallen in love with a Partibon, Maria, Giorgio and Elena's country cousin who, like Elena and Alessandra Tava, is left expecting her dead hero's child.

Again the choice of a name is significant. Of all possible Latinate names, Pasinetti has chosen Massimo, which, even to those least familiar with Italian history,

clearly associates the character with the nineteenth-century patriot, Massimo d'Azeglio. We have here another possible curious link with Ruggero. The full name of this old family of *marchesi*, located principally in Northern Italy, is Taparelli d'Azeglio; the last of the line (at the end of the nineteenth century) was Emanuele Taparelli d'Azeglio. With not too much linguistic juggling, the root of the first part of the name gives us Tava, and the old Marchese's name, it will be remembered, is precisely Emanuele. This interpretation may be somewhat remote, but it is difficult to determine to what lengths a linguistically inventive author may go in devising rather private plays on words.

Massimo and Ruggero may be seen as representative of elements of Italy's past, both heroic: on the one hand, there is Rome and her history — stalwart, stolid, waging wars — and on the other, the legendary tradition of romance with its grace, individual courage, and chivalry. The ideal of Roman *virtù* would seem to be an exterior one Italians impose on themselves, and Mussolini's exaltation of ancient Rome was just such an attempt.

Rosso veneziano, with all the questions it raises concerning attitudes toward art, love, family, and country, takes essentially the form of a quest: Giorgio and Elena are obsessed by the figure of their long-absent uncle Marco, whom they have never known, whom they try to find, and who does eventually return to Venice. As we pointed out earlier, Marco, by his simple, Italian name is identified as one of the Partibon *artisti*. What is more, from the beginning, the *fact* of his name is important, for it may never be mentioned in his mother's presence. Marco is also tied to Venice by his very name, the resources of which the author has not neglected. Giorgio and Elena are telling their fables

of Il Saggio to the Angelone children:

Allora parlò Elena: — Bambine, avete mai sentito questo nome: Marco?

— Il leone con le ali, — Bianca disse. E subito aggiunse: — È il nome del nostro zio perduto.

Ci fu un lungo silenzio stupito. Sopra le bambine, gli sguardi di Giorgio ed Elena s'incontrarono.

(p. 151)

The name is also emphasized by the curious form (qualified as "straniera") with which Marco introduces himself to Ruggero and to Giorgio: "Il mio nome è Marco Partibon."

Pasinetti's careful choice of names extends even to secondary and minor characters. We have already mentioned Ersilia, who identifies with the country branch of the family to the extent that she would like to construct a family tomb at Corniano. The Corniano Partibons manage to keep a certain distinguished, if raffish, quality about them: there is Odo, with his old-fashioned, medieval-sounding name, whose father was Romeo. Odo's wife is generally called "la messicana," which emphasizes the fact that this branch of the family has always moved about, whereas the Venetian branch has tended to remain in place. The distinguished quality remaining in the family is revealed by the allusion to the "aristocratic" beauty of Odo's daughter Maria, who appears to have been named with reference to her mother's faith and her own lengthily described piety.

We have already mentioned one of the most interesting names and characters of *Rosso veneziano*: Enzo Bolchi. The one totally vile personage in the novel, he provokes Giorgio's most violent reactions: Giorgio goes so far as to warn that Bolchi's name should not be pronounced too often or the air will have to be disinfected. Within the ambit of Italian,

Bolchi immediately suggests the *bolgie* of the Inferno; at one point, Giorgio says:

Sempre fin da bambino, il mio desiderio è stato quello: isolare Bolchi, tirarlo fuori da quello sfondo oscuro, da quelle sue allusioni a potenze minacciose che lui può metter in moto, bloccarlo, costringerlo al corpo a corpo.

(p. 553)

However, in the joycean kind of play on words, not uncommon in the polyglot Pasinetti is, we hear the echo of English "bulky," and Bolchi is, indeed, a large man. This impression is borne out, for example, in the description of his duel with Ruggero:

. . . [il] respiro sempre più grosso di Bolchi (Ruggero pareva non avesse neppur bisogno di respirare, si batteva con un'eleganza tranquilla e facile) . . .

(p. 117)

Another sinister aspect of this character is his once having gone by the name Enzo Bolchi Blumenfeld: whereas using Blumenfeld once implied a tenuous relationship with a family of Austrian Jewish bankers, the suppression of it, as Giorgio reminds us frequently, is a reflection of the current political situation.

If Pasinetti's consciousness of the evocative power of proper names is indicated, in *Rosso Veneziano*, by Giorgio's explication of the name Blumenfeld, it is exposed fully, in *La Confusione*, by an abundance of such comments, many even more direct and detailed. Not only is the reader set before a fascinating array of exquisitely chosen names (at random, let us mention Ovidio Semenzato, a professor of history; Gianni Merlo, a piano-player at chic social gatherings; Quarto Martelli, of Paduan nobility, whose coat-of-arms is in his very name); he is also offered deliberate reflections on those names.

Thus, of Genziana Horst, who despite an apparent independence and strength, is really as fragile and timid as her flower-name suggests, Pasinetti ultimately tells us:

Il senatore Mario Horst . . . aveva messo nome Genziana a sua figlia perché quel fiore gli ricordava l'alpe della sua giovinezza.

(p. 293)²

And we may note, in passing, that Genziana's curiously un-Italian surname is also connected with nature: it is German for "thicket."

Ugo Debaldè is a name that would have given us matter for reflection had the author not already commented on it through the other characters. Genziana's brother-in-law, Rodolfo Piglioli-Spada says:

Sarà che me lo ricordo anche perché un nome più curioso l'ho incontrato di rado: un nome, voglio dire, più difficilmente collocabile. Mi corregga se sbaglio. Cos'è, di origine francese? Con quella grafia?

(p. 64)

And he says essentially the same thing less than 30 pages later. On the same name, Pasinetti has Clement Benzon Blumenfeld, who is "disgustingly tri-lingual," make the following commentary:

E quanto mi sono sbizzarrito, sempre, su quel nome. Dal primo momento che l'ho sentito (e deve esser stato durante l'infanzia) sia per pura fantasia mia, sia per gli echi suscitati da esso per ovvie ragioni negli antri della mia mente di linguista maniaco, mi si è associato a idee di corruzione, e ad immagini di castigo. *Debaldè*: ho la visione di un uomo sfasciato dai vizi; ho quella d'un uomo cui siano stati strappati, a titolo punitivo, tutti i capelli; ho quella d'un uomo escluso, bocciato da un circolo rispettabile, per motivi d'onore. *Debaldè*. . . .

(p. 110)

We have here a very joycean association of inexact

linguistic echoes: *Debaldè*, *débauché*, and bald or "debalded," however fanciful the English may be. Clement's terms "escluso" and "bocciato" seem to lead us to English "blackballed," which includes many of the sounds in *Debaldè*.

Clement's name too elicits commentary: he is the son of a Venetian woman, Nicoletta Benzon, and of a Blumenfeld, related to the Blumenfelds of the first novel. His middle name is alluded to once by Odo Partibon's émigré son, Bernardo (who is moreover Clement's brother-in-law, being married to Clare, his half-sister). Clement himself has this to say:

All'uso americano mi è stato applicato, è vero, un nome "di mezzo" e questo è il suo nome di famiglia; mi chiamo Clement Benzon come altri potrebbero chiamarsi Giovanni Battista: così spiegavo la cosa, tanto per dare un'idea, agli altri ragazzini nei periodi che stavamo a Venezia. Il sospetto sarebbe: ha voluto lei incuneare nel mio nome questo fossile dogale? E ciò che crede chi la conosca superficialmente. In realtà fu un'idea di mio padre, israelita d'origine austriaca e matto di Venezia. Quel fossile si è poi tanto rimescolato nei movimenti della nostra vita che si presta benissimo ai giochi che ci faccio sopra. Con quel gusto linguistico col quale cerco alle volte di alleviare la noia, ne faccio p. es. un nome germanico o scandinavo, Bentzon o addirittura Bengtson; del resto io per molti rispetti (alpinismo ad es.) sono un nordico.

(p. 97)

More explicitly than elsewhere, the author here lets us glimpse his predilection for multilingual play.

The onomastic richness of both *Rosso veneziano* and *La Confusione* is an indisputable and striking element of Pasinetti's fictional art. Attuned to the special poetry of baptism, the author invents names which, never merely allegorical, add both depth and a lyric texture to the definition of his characters. He stands

together, in this respect, with Balzac and Flaubert, Joyce and Durrell.

NOTES

1. All quotations from *Rosso veneziano* are taken from the 1959 edition (Casa editrice Carlo Colombo).
2. All quotations from *La Confusione* are from the 1964 edition (Bompiani).

An Albanian Poet From Italy

Girolamo De Rada: 1814-1903

ROBERTO RUBERTO

At times one wonders why a poet has been neglected; but what else could happen to a poet belonging to an almost completely unknown literature? In fact, apart from Albanologists and the Albanians themselves, few are those who know that there is an Italo-Albanian literature. It would be difficult to present Girolamo De Rada without talking first about the culture to which he belongs.

Following the death of their leader Skanderbeg in 1468, a large number of Albanians, rather than fall under the Turkish rule, fled to Italy. Settling in Southern Italy and in Sicily, they founded villages and towns, and kept alive their language, their traditions and, in most cases, their Greek-Catholic rite. But politically they soon became assimilated to the new country, so that by the nineteenth century they took a valuable and active part in the formation of the Kingdom of Italy, winning special praise from Garibaldi himself. They contributed several political men to the Italian parliament, among them Francesco Crispi. Today, after five centuries, the Italo-Albanians are losing more and more their cultural heritage. They have always been bilingual, Italian being their official language; but the number of towns where Albanian is no longer spoken is increasing. According to a motion promoting the teaching of Albanian in Italo-Albanian schools presented to the Italian parliament in 1964, the number of Albanian speaking towns is 63, with